

INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS

# GROUP PROJECT PORTFOLIO

*Investing in Mongolia: A Country Analysis Report and Presentation*

## **Group Project — Country: Mongolia**

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# 1 Country Analysis Report of Mongolia

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*Learning Team Group Project Report (30%) — a country analysis evaluating whether a Canadian company should expand its operations into Mongolia, covering the country's macro environment, factor endowments, and the risks and benefits of doing business there. Co-authored with Geena Abraham Edakkad, Aakarsh Ambili Shaju, Anton Francis, and Sam George Kolath.*

## Executive Summary

This comprehensive report examines Mongolia's economic landscape, political system, cultural dimensions, and business opportunities as part of an evaluation of whether our company should expand its foreign operations into the country. It explores Mongolia's abundant natural resources, particularly in mining, while also highlighting efforts to diversify the economy into sectors such as agriculture, renewable energy, technology, and tourism. Despite potential risks associated with mining activities, such as economic instability, political tensions, and environmental challenges, the report finds that the benefits of investing in Mongolia — including diverse business prospects beyond mining and the country's potential for economic transformation — outweigh those risks.

The report concludes that the advantages of investing in Mongolia outweigh the challenges, particularly due to the country's well-delineated legislative framework and the growing potential of non-mining sectors. It recommends a cautious approach, emphasizing the importance of strategic planning, risk management, cultural understanding, ethical business conduct, and flexible business models to navigate challenges and seize opportunities. Overall, the report presents Mongolia as an emerging market with immense potential for growth and development, and proposes a carefully considered expansion strategy to establish a robust business presence while contributing to the country's economic advancement.

## Country's Macro Environment

### Country Description

Mongolia has a population of less than 3 million. Mongolia is unique in that it resembles a corridor from which millions of people around the world come. Mongolia is known as the "land of eternal blue skies" thanks to more than 250 bright days each year. It is a landlocked country in Central East Asia, the 18th largest country in the world, bordering Russia and China. The country is divided into 21 provinces, or aimags, and Ulaanbaatar serves as its capital, housing 45% of the country's population. The main industries in Mongolia are pastoralism and mining; about 80% of its exports are primarily gold and copper, though both industries have declined in recent decades in favor of the service trade. Mongolia is also the world's second-largest producer of Kashmiri goat hair, behind only China. Most of the population, about 95%, identifies as Mongolian or one of the major Mongolian people groups such as the Buryat, Dorvod, or Bayad, with the remaining 5% made up mostly of Kazakhs and Russians.

Mongolia is considered a developing country whose economy is mainly based on natural resources, especially the mining of copper, gold, coal, and other minerals. Because of its vast territory and sparse population, Mongolia faces challenges in building infrastructure and sustainability, but efforts are being made to improve road and transport networks. Although IT infrastructure has improved, urban-rural disparities may still exist. The mining industry sustains Mongolia's economy and accounts for a significant portion of its GDP, while traditional agriculture, especially livestock, remains an important component of the economy. Because of its geographic location, Mongolia has important trade links with Russia and China. Mongolia's mining sector has attracted significant foreign investment, though the country's

appetite for international investors is often influenced by global commodity prices. By improving its legal system, the Mongolian government has taken steps to create an environment that is attractive to international investors, and large global mining companies can find operations in Mongolia alongside multinational companies active in manufacturing and telecommunications. Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI) can provide an estimate of the level of corruption in Mongolia, which is important to note can vary across industries.

### Political System, Situation, and Stability

Mongolia is a parliamentary republic with the President as Head of State and the Prime Minister as the executive branch. The Great Khural, or Parliament, is the highest legislative body, composed of representatives of various political parties. Mongolia holds regular parliamentary and presidential elections, and changes in political leadership can affect national policies and strategies. Mongolia's economy is closely linked to its mining sector, so changes in commodity prices can affect economic stability; efforts have been made to diversify the economy to improve financial stability. Social factors such as concerns about inequality and urban-rural differences can affect general social well-being. Mongolia maintains relationships with neighboring countries such as Russia and China that must be balanced to maintain its geopolitical position, and is a member of many international organizations while maintaining diplomatic relations with governments around the world.

Mongolia has implemented legal reforms to improve its institutions and governance, and the rule of law is essential for political and social stability; a healthy democracy requires an active media and public. Mongolia has a Foreign Investment Law that sets out the legal framework for foreign investment, providing specific rights and protections for foreign investors and setting the conditions under which they can operate. Mongolian law also protects intellectual property rights — Mongolia is a member of the World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO) and has laws protecting trademarks, patents, and copyrights — and as a member of the World Trade Organization (WTO), Mongolia is committed to free trade free of barriers and tariffs. Mongolia can offer incentives such as tax breaks and customs duty reductions to attract foreign investment in certain sectors, and has agreements to avoid double taxation. Foreigners are prohibited from owning land in Mongolia, so foreign investors typically lease land for their businesses. The law also defines dispute settlement procedures, including the use of international arbitration, and environmental law applies to certain industries, especially mining, with which international investors need to comply. International investors must also be aware of currency exchange and capital repatriation laws, as well as business and employment laws governing recruitment, working conditions, and labor rights.

### Economic Conditions and Stability

Historically, Mongolia's economy has relied primarily on mining, especially of copper, gold, and coal, so economic growth is closely linked to global commodity prices. The Mongolian Tugrik (MNT) is the country's chief currency, and inflation, foreign exchange reserves, and trade balance can all affect currency stability; Mongolia has suffered from financial stability issues in the past, and its exchange rate is sensitive to foreign exchange fluctuations. Like many developing countries, Mongolia has borrowed externally to finance infrastructure and economic development, and management of this external debt is crucial for economic stability. Mongolia has experienced periods of both high and low inflation, and government fiscal policies such as taxes and public spending affect economic stability and the government's ability to manage its budget. The dominance of the mining industry can be problematic because it exposes the country to price fluctuations, so efforts have been made to diversify the economy and make it less dependent on mining. Mongolia has tried to attract foreign direct investment to help

develop infrastructure and expand non-mining sectors, and its trade balance of exports and imports can influence its foreign exchange reserves. The Mongolian government has undertaken reforms to improve business conditions, attract investment, and strengthen the economy.

## Culture

The culture of Mongolia is unique: Sarlagtay (2014) notes that Mongolia has a nomadic culture but, compared to other nomadic countries such as Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, it also has a strong Buddhist influence. Mongolians traditionally wear clothing called the "deel," showcasing their rich cultural heritage, and the annual Naadam festival — a traditional sports competition — attracts many tourists every year.

## Workforce Skills

Mongolia has a young population: as of 2019, youth between the ages of 15 and 34 made up the largest demographic group in the nation, numbering over a million and accounting for 34.9 percent of the total population, making them a potential resource for the country's economic growth. The Ministry of Education and Science has established non-formal, remote learning initiatives supporting the development of fundamental skills, often in collaboration with non-governmental organizations and other government agencies; of the 1,200,000 adults in Mongolia, 100,000 participate in distance learning. By the end of 2022, Mongolia had a population of over 3.4 million people and a high literacy rate, with about 1 million of its 1.2 million-person labor force employed. The country excels in certain technical fields, such as mining engineering and renewable energy technologies, and plant and machine operators and assemblers had the highest average wage, at 2,282,200 MNT (around 660 USD).

## Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions

Cultural dimensions help multinationals seeking to do business in developing countries, since national culture can be a major determinant of a multinational organization's success (Dartey-Baah, 2013). Managing and conducting business in culturally distinct regions of the world can be difficult at times, so research into Mongolia's cultural dimensions helps clarify its people and their values (Rarick et al., 2014):

1. Power Distance: Mongolia scores 93 on this index, meaning Mongolian society respects authoritative figures and appreciates hierarchical connections.
2. Masculinity: Mongolia scores high on masculinity.
3. Individualism: With a score of 37, Mongolia is classified as a collectivistic society. Strong family and regional ties make Mongolians cautious of outsiders, and their nomadic lifestyle depends on collaboration for survival.
4. Uncertainty Avoidance: Mongolia scores moderately on this index. Individuals are often willing to take some chances and are receptive to new ideas and change, though some preference remains for stability and established norms.
5. Long-Term Orientation: Mongolia scores 50 on this index. Personal debt is rising, and resources are being used now since they might not be accessible later.
6. Indulgence: With a moderate score, Mongolia maintains a balance between self-control and satisfying basic human impulses.

These findings carry implications relative to Canada: in Mongolian culture, one would anticipate greater power sharing with more forceful and competitive people, who would probably be less open to change

and risk-taking than Canadians, favoring stability and well-established regulations. Understanding a country's cultural dimensions is crucial for businesses since it affects workplace behavior, corporate culture, ethics, corporate social responsibility, and management techniques (Rarick et al., 2014).

## **Factor Endowments**

### **Basic Factors of Production — Land and Natural Resources**

Mongolia is distinguished by its substantial reserves of copper, gold, coal, and uranium, all of which contribute to its advantageous standing in the commodities market (World Bank, 2021). Mongolia's copper and gold reserves suggest promising avenues for exploration, extraction, and export, offering considerable appeal to investors and industry stakeholders (Mongolian Ministry of Mining and Heavy Industry, 2022), while its uranium reserves may serve as a crucial resource in facilitating nuclear energy given growing global demand for clean energy sources (World Nuclear Association, 2021).

### **Basic Factors of Production — Labor Force**

Mongolia's young and growing labor force encourages economic growth and investment, and its educated, skilled workforce attracts labor-intensive businesses and services. As the country connects with global advances, preparation of the labor force for the contemporary economy is emphasized (World Economic Forum, 2021). Mongolia competes globally in manual and technical sectors with an adaptable, skilled workforce of over 1.36 million (Asian Development Outlook, 2022), and the Mongolian Ministry of Education, Culture, Science, and Sports (2020) reports that education has produced a trained workforce able to work in technology, finance, and industry.

### **Basic Factors of Production — Renewable Energy Potential**

Mongolia's expansive, windy steppes give it significant wind energy potential — the World Bank (2019) recognizes Mongolia as possessing among the greatest per-capita wind energy potential worldwide. Mongolia also benefits from significant solar irradiation, and the government has acknowledged this potential by initiating projects for both on-grid and off-grid solar use (Asian Development Bank, 2017). Mongolia's renewable energy potential is significant for addressing local energy needs and fostering regional collaboration (International Renewable Energy Agency, 2020).

### **Advanced Factors of Production — Education and Training**

Mongolia's dedication to education is crucial for fostering a skilled workforce for growing sectors. The Mongolian Ministry of Education has implemented reforms to equip students with vital skills (2020), leading to an increasing number of people with advanced education — crucial for technology-reliant industries (World Bank, 2021). The Mongolian Ministry of Health (2021) also recognizes that investment in medical education is crucial for developing a competent healthcare workforce, highlighting Mongolia's deliberate investment in human capital.

### **Advanced Factors of Production — Economic Growth, Technology, and Infrastructure**

Mongolia's economic growth reflects a shift toward a more diverse and advanced economic structure, with the expansion of economic activity beyond conventional sectors promoting more sophisticated manufacturing capabilities. A vibrant technology industry has developed, mostly concentrated in the capital, Ulaanbaatar, where startups in fintech, e-commerce, and information technology have found a favorable ecosystem for advancement (Naidansuren, 2020) — exemplified by initiatives like the "Digital Mongolia" program (Government of Mongolia, 2020). The Asian Development Bank (ADB) has played a

crucial role in assisting road construction initiatives (ADB, 2018), and the Trans-Mongolian Railway, connecting Ulaanbaatar with Russia and China, serves as a crucial commerce corridor enabling the efficient movement of goods.

### Promising Business Opportunities

**Tourism and Hospitality:** Mongolia's captivating landscapes and rich cultural history create optimal conditions for ecotourism and adventure tourism (Mongolian National Tourism Centre, 2021), and its nomadic culture and traditions provide an ideal foundation for upscale resorts offering immersive, culturally rich experiences.

**Mining and Natural Resources:** Mongolia's abundant mineral resources have garnered substantial interest from domestic and global enterprises, and its strategic geographic location positions it as a significant participant in the global commodities market, offering opportunities for economic growth and partnerships between domestic and international stakeholders (World Bank, 2021; Mongolian Ministry of Mining and Heavy Industry, 2022).

**Agriculture and Agribusiness:** Mongolia's historical proficiency in livestock agriculture — managing flocks of sheep, goats, and cattle — enables the generation of superior-grade meat and fiber (UN Food and Agriculture Organization, 2020), while increasing adoption of crop agriculture enhances food security and economic diversification. Continuous modernization of agricultural methods and infrastructure establishes a favorable setting for sustainable agribusiness (Asian Development Bank, 2020).

**Technology and Innovation:** Ulaanbaatar's technology scene has experienced significant growth, creating a favorable setting for entrepreneurs and corporations to develop advanced solutions across e-commerce, fintech, and sustainable energy. Startups are utilizing this ecosystem to spearhead digital platforms that improve accessibility and efficiency (Naidansuren, 2020).

**Educational Services:** Mongolia's highly educated workforce, resulting from continuous enhancements to the education system (Mongolian Ministry of Education, Culture, Science, and Sports, 2020), facilitates the emergence of private schools, language centers, and vocational training institutions, creating a conducive climate for growth in private educational services.

**Renewable Energy Resources:** Mongolia's emphasis on developing renewable energy technology aligns with international sustainability objectives, demonstrating its dedication to technical progress in clean energy (International Renewable Energy Agency, 2020).

### Analysis: Risks and Benefits of Doing Business in Mongolia

#### Risks

Mongolia presents a high-risk political and economic environment for a company looking to expand into the country. Its economy is currently unstable, characterized by high inflation, high fiscal risks, and restrictive external credit conditions (Soni, 2018, p. 111), indicating a high cost of living that reduces citizens' purchasing power — the business could face challenges getting people to buy its products in an unstable economic state. High interest rates also make it challenging for people to borrow, and Mongolia has a high unemployment rate with rapidly falling labor force participation. Accelerating inflation and high interest rates contribute to fiscal risks such as high taxes and limited government spending, and Mongolia has a strong overreliance on external funding, translating to high fiscal exposure. There is, however, potential for a higher trade surplus as Mongolia increases mining-related imports from China.

Mongolia's mining sector, which accounts for almost half of the country's GDP, is highly dependent on trade, and COVID-era restrictions significantly disrupted trade on the Chinese border — similar disruptions could significantly affect Mongolia's imports and exports. The country's overdependence on mining also risks volatility, and mining activities have caused significant environmental degradation and pollution that the company should consider. The education sector suffers from limited funding due to a strained economy, and people from low socioeconomic backgrounds have limited access to quality education, lowering the number of competitively skilled employees in the labor force. Mongolia is trying to develop its agricultural sector to reduce overdependence on mining, but faces barriers like harsh weather conditions, limited resources, and land degradation, meaning businesses need to implement sustainable practices for long-term effects.

High fiscal risks also indicate minimal consumer spending, which would directly affect the business's profitability, and the company should refrain from investing in Mongolia's mining sector specifically because of these factors. The country's institutional framework has multiple loopholes that minimize the capacity to manage public resources efficiently, and Mongolian citizens have shown continual concern about rising inequality and poverty, contributing to political unease since the 2021 presidential elections. Key corruption scandals and embezzlement concerning state coal exports have fueled frustration and triggered demonstrations demanding the government cut wasteful public spending. Mongolia is also highly dependent on Russia for imports and has distanced itself from the war with Ukraine, which remains at an all-time high and could present challenges for international trade if the company proceeds with expansion.

## Benefits

Mongolia also boasts key benefits, including significant mining resources that are a major economic driver — Mongolia's current GDP growth is 5.5% with a yearly inflation rate of 9.7% (Locatelli, 2019, p. 2021) — and its vast natural resources continually attract foreign investors, especially in mining, which generates significant revenue through key outputs like copper, gold, coal, and iron. Key investors in Mongolia's mining sector include Japan, the US, South Korea, and Canada, and the mining outlook remains favorable given rising demand for minerals. Vulnerabilities have also been curbed by government efforts to diversify the economy into agriculture, tourism, and renewable energy, presenting additional business opportunities, and the government has prioritized promoting foreign investment in sectors other than mining (Soni, 2018, p. 112).

Mongolia also has vast agricultural resources the company could leverage to diversify revenue, and the World Bank notes new opportunities for Mongolia to develop its private sector and business environment by investing in SMEs. Presently, weak linkages between mining and the rest of the economy create multiple vulnerabilities, and SMEs are especially vulnerable to restrictive current conditions; removing these barriers would let SMEs take center stage in the economic diversification the country needs. Mongolia's strategic geographic position between China and Russia provides transit opportunities for trade, and the two countries are exploring new areas for collaboration that would strengthen economic ties and boost regional stability through Mongolia's balanced foreign policy.

According to Hofstede's insights, Mongolia is a collectivist society with strong familial and religious orientations, so the company could find it challenging to be accepted and integrated into society and must make extra efforts to remain connected and relatable. Mongolia's motivation toward achievement and success scores low, at 29 — people value relationships, quality of life, and work-life balance, so the company should consider implementing flexible work hours and competitive compensation packages, and establish relationship-based business partnerships built on trust. Mongolia's high power distance index

(93) indicates that citizens are accustomed to power inequalities within their society, and corruption has become normalized among those in power who exploit public funds; the company would align well with Mongolia's culture by implementing a centralized decision-making structure.

### Do the Risks Outweigh the Benefits?

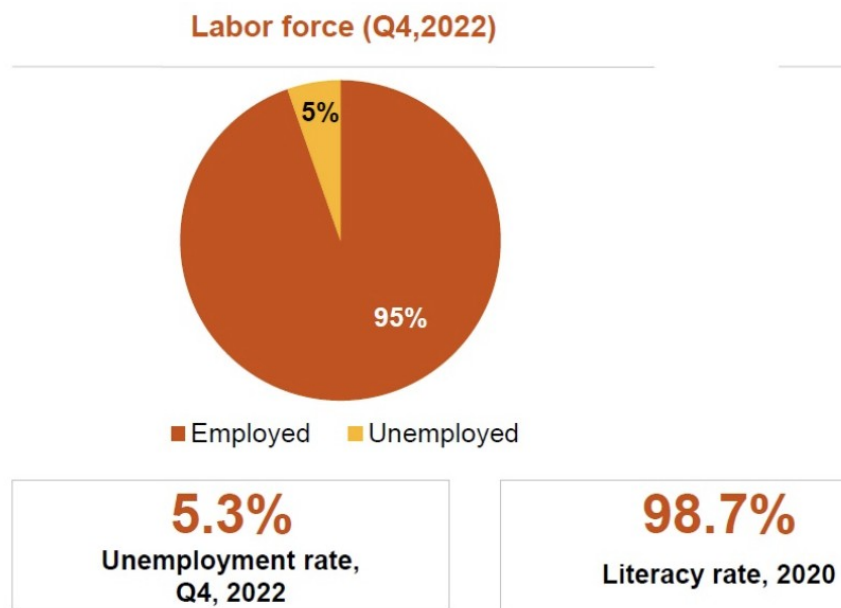
The benefits outweigh the risks in this evaluation of Mongolia's political climate, economic conditions, and geographic location. The nation possesses well-delineated legislation that results in uniform judgments, deterring corruption, and Mongolia possesses a diversifying economy characterized by strong growth in businesses beyond mining.

### Recommendation & Conclusion

It is recommended that our company move forward with plans to expand into Mongolia after a thorough study of the country's political, economic, cultural, and workforce factors. A favorable political climate, strong business benefits, abundant natural resources, and a growing market all make for compelling growth and development possibilities. By carefully evaluating the risks and planning for the future, the company can build a strong foothold in Mongolia and contribute to its economic growth.

### Appendices

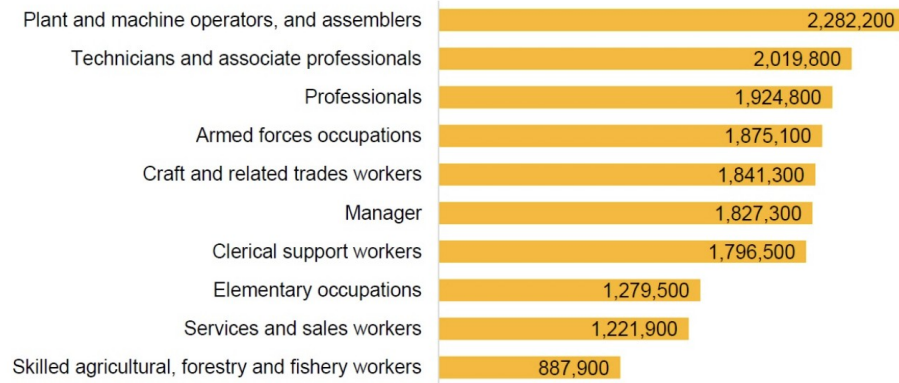
The charts below are referenced in the report above as supporting evidence for the labor force, salary, and cultural-dimension comparisons discussed in each section.



*Source: National Statistics Office*

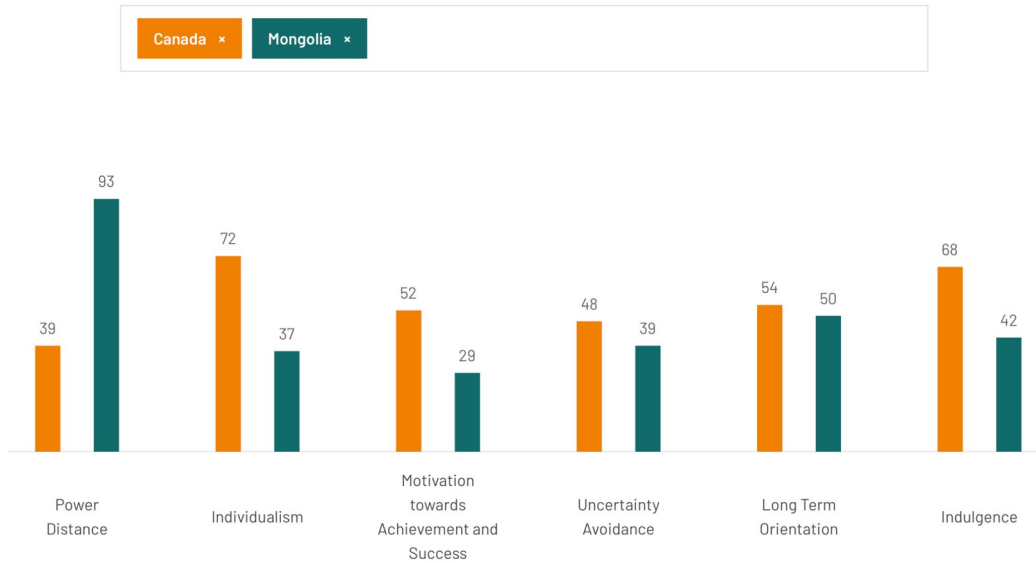
*Appendix A — Employment, unemployment, and literacy rate, 2022 (Source: National Statistics Office)*

**Average salary by occupation (In MNT, 2022)**



Source: National Statistics Office

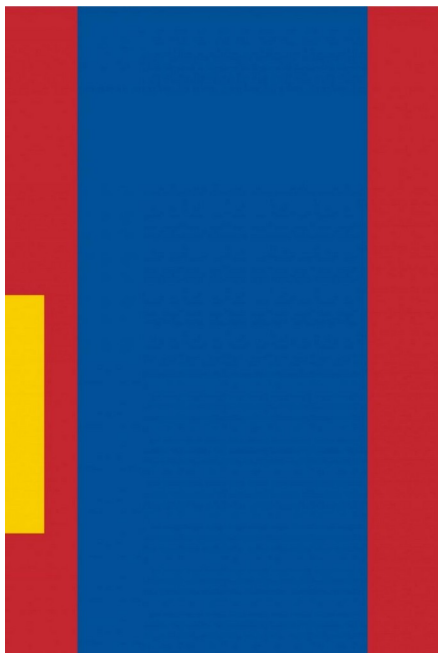
Appendix B — Average salary by occupation, 2022, in MNT (Source: National Statistics Office)



Appendix C — Hofstede's country comparison: Canada vs. Mongolia (Source: hofstede-insights.com)

## 2 Presentation: Investing in Mongolia

*Learning Team Group Project Presentation (20%) — a slide deck prepared to present the same country analysis and recommendation, shown here as a full walkthrough of the deck.*



### Investing in Mongolia

This executive report analyzes the opportunities and risks of expanding our operations into Mongolia. We will explore the country's political situation, economic conditions, cultural factors, workforce skills, and more to provide a comprehensive recommendation to the CEO.

Team Members :

- ANTON FRANCIS
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*Slide 1 — Title slide — Investing in Mongolia*

### Country Overview

Mongolia, a landlocked country in East Asia, is known for its vast expanses of untouched natural beauty, including the iconic Gobi Desert and the rolling steppes. With a population of approximately 3 million people, Mongolia has a rich history and a growing economy.



#### Diverse Landscapes

Mongolia offers breathtaking landscapes, from the rugged mountains to the vast grasslands.



#### Cultural Heritage

The traditional Mongolian yurt, or "ger," is a symbol of their nomadic lifestyle and heritage.



#### Horse Culture

Horses play an essential role in Mongolian culture, symbolizing freedom and independence.

*Slide 2 — Country overview — landscapes, population, and nomadic culture*

## Political Situation

Mongolia is a parliamentary republic with a multi-party system. It has a stable political environment and a commitment to democratic principles. The government has implemented reforms to attract foreign investment and promote economic growth.

### Stable Governance

Mongolia has a strong foundation of governance that provides stability for businesses operating in the country.

### Foreign Investment Incentives

The government offers attractive incentives and policies to encourage foreign investment in key sectors.

### Democratic Principles

Mongolia's commitment to democratic principles ensures transparency and fairness in business operations.

*Slide 3 — Political situation — stable governance and investment incentives*

## Legislation and Economic Conditions

Mongolia has made significant progress in improving its legal framework for businesses. The country has implemented comprehensive laws to protect intellectual property rights, encourage competition, and ensure fair trade practices. In terms of economic conditions, Mongolia offers favorable factors for investment, including its abundant natural resources and strategic geographical location.

1

### Legal Framework

Mongolia has developed robust legislation to protect businesses' rights and promote fair competition.

2

### Natural Resources

Mongolia is rich in natural resources, including coal, copper, gold, and uranium, providing potential business opportunities.

3

### Geographical Advantage

Mongolia's strategic location between Russia and China offers unique advantages for international trade and logistics.

*Slide 4 — Legislation and economic conditions — legal framework and natural resources*

## Cultural Considerations

Mongolian culture is deeply rooted in nomadic traditions, with strong influences from Tibetan Buddhism. Understanding and respecting the local customs and traditions is crucial for successful business operations in Mongolia. Building relationships based on mutual trust and respect is essential.



### Traditional Attire

Traditional Mongolian clothing, such as the elaborate "deel," reflects the rich cultural heritage of the country.



### Buddhist Monasteries

Buddhism has a significant influence on Mongolian culture, with numerous monasteries dotting the landscape.



### Naadam Festival

The Naadam Festival, featuring traditional sports and cultural events, is a highlight of Mongolian cultural celebrations.

*Slide 5 — Cultural considerations — traditional attire, Buddhist monasteries, and the Naadam festival*

## Workforce Skills and Population Demography

Mongolia has a young and growing workforce, offering a pool of skilled labor for various industries. The country's education system has made strides in providing quality education and vocational training to equip workers with the necessary skills for the evolving job

### Youthful Workforce

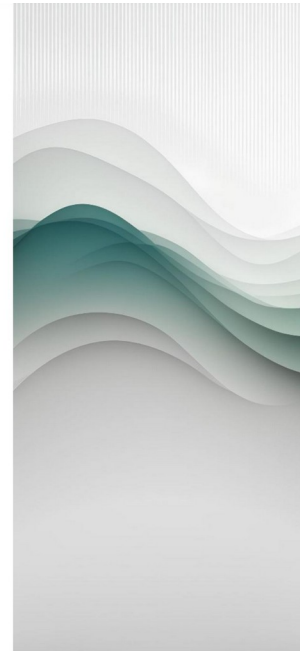
The majority of Mongolia's population is under the age of 35, providing a large pool of energetic and motivated workers.

### Educational Advancements

Mongolia has made significant investments in education, ensuring a skilled workforce ready to contribute to economic growth.

### Technical Expertise

The country excels in certain technical fields, such as mining engineering and renewable energy technologies.



*Slide 6 — Workforce skills and population demography — a young, educated labor force*



## Basic and Advanced Factors of Production

Mongolia possesses abundant natural resources, including minerals, such as coal, copper, and gold. These resources present opportunities for businesses in the mining and extraction sectors. Moreover, the country's unique geography provides potential for renewable energy projects, such as wind and solar power.

- 1 **Mining Resources**  
Mongolia's vast mineral reserves offer opportunities for mining projects and the extraction of valuable resources.
- 2 **Renewable Energy Potential**  
The country's windy steppes and ample sunshine make Mongolia an ideal location for renewable energy projects.
- 3 **Innovation and Technology**  
Mongolia has the potential to embrace innovation and technology, driving advancements in various sectors.

Slide 7 — Basic and advanced factors of production — mining, renewable energy, and innovation

## Risks and Benefits of Doing Business

While Mongolia offers attractive opportunities, there are certain risks to consider. Adequate risk analysis and mitigation strategies are crucial for successful business operations in the country. The benefits of expanding into Mongolia include access to its vast natural resources, a growing market, and the possibility of establishing a competitive edge.



### Risk Analysis

It is essential to conduct a comprehensive risk analysis to address potential challenges and devise appropriate mitigation strategies.



### Growing Market

Mongolia's growing economy presents opportunities for businesses seeking to expand their market presence.



### Competitive Edge

Mongolia's rich natural resources, such as cashmere, offer possibilities for companies to establish a competitive advantage.

Slide 8 — Risks and benefits of doing business in Mongolia

## Recommendation: Expanding into Mongolia

After a comprehensive analysis of Mongolia's political, economic, cultural, and workforce factors, it is recommended that our company proceed with expanding into the country. The favorable political environment, attractive investment incentives, abundance of natural resources, and growing market present exciting opportunities for growth and development. With careful risk assessment and strategic planning, we can establish a strong presence in Mongolia and contribute to its economic prosperity.



*Slide 9 — Recommendation — expanding into Mongolia*

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*Slide 10 — References*